

Who's who?

THE CHARACTERS CREATED by Shakespeare have such an enduring quality that they are still brought to life every day around the world in countless productions. Here we examine some of Shakespeare's best-known characters. The plays in which they appear are noted at the end of each profile.

HEROES

Shakespeare's most famous heroes are those that appear in the tragedy plays. These men are often essentially noble, but have a character flaw, such as pride, that leads to their downfall. Some tragic characters, however, are just plain villains.

BRUTUS

Marcus Brutus is a man of noble principles. Although he leads a plot to kill his friend, Julius Caesar, it is only for the good of the Roman state and after a great deal of heartfelt and painful deliberation. He kills himself when he loses the war with Caesar's avengers. (*Julius Caesar*)

CORIOLANUS

Coriolanus is a brave and proud Roman general whose arrogance makes the ordinary people of Rome reject his wishes to be made consul. He joins Rome's enemies and leads them against his own city. Finally, he agrees to spare Rome although he knows he will be killed. (*Coriolanus*)

HAMLET

The prince of Denmark is Shakespeare's most complex character. He thinks too deeply about everything and feels out of place in a corrupt world. His father, the king, has been murdered by his uncle for the throne and the queen, Hamlet's mother. Hamlet's tragedy is that he is unsuited to the role of avenger, which is imposed on him by his father's ghost. (*Hamlet*)

KING LEAR

King Lear's flaws are lack of awareness, vanity, and an uncontrollable temper. He fails to see which of his daughters truly loves him, sending him on a path to madness and death. (*King Lear*).

MACBETH

After a prophecy by witches and under pressure from his wife, Macbeth murders the king to take the crown himself. His ambition transforms him from a loyal soldier into a monster. (*Macbeth*)



Laurence Fishburne plays Othello in the 1995 film adaptation.

OTHELLO

Othello's vulnerability stems from his position as an outsider (he is a Moor from northern Africa) and a soldier in sophisticated Venice. He is a very trusting soul and is easily manipulated by his evil comrade Iago into believing that his beloved bride, Desdemona, has committed adultery. Othello's inability to control his suspicions leads him to kill his wife. When Othello finds out that his jealousy was unfounded, he commits suicide. (*Othello*)

HEROINES



Miranda in *The Tempest*

Shakespeare's women can be tragic or comic, strong or weak, and often cross-dress as men to gain more freedom.

BEATRICE

Strong-willed and clever, Beatrice enters into a war of words with Benedict. She falls in love with him and eventually marries him. (*Much Ado About Nothing*)

DESDEMONA

The honest, loving, and naive wife of Othello who is unjustly murdered by her suspicious husband. (*Othello*)

HERMIONE

The wife of a jealous king who accuses her of adultery when she is pregnant. In a moving speech, she defends herself with great honor, but must fake her own death to survive. (*A Winter's Tale*)

ISABELLA

A nun who leaves her calling to help her brother Claudio. The only way she can save him is to have sex with an official, but she cleverly arranges for another woman to take her place. (*Measure for Measure*)

KATHERINA

The feisty bride of Petruchio, who teaches her how to be an obedient wife. In modern productions, Katherina merely pretends to be a sweet-tempered wife in order to control her husband. (*Taming of the Shrew*)

MIRANDA

Miranda grows up on an enchanted island with her magician father. She falls in love with a shipwrecked prince. (*The Tempest*)

OPHELIA

A fragile young woman who, following her father's death and Hamlet's rejection of her, is driven mad and drowns herself. (*Hamlet*)

PORTIA

One of Shakespeare's strongest, bravest, and most intelligent heroines, Portia disguises herself as a lawyer to save the man she loves. (*The Merchant of Venice*)

VIOLA

After surviving a shipwreck, and believing her twin brother to be dead, Viola disguises herself as a man and works for a count, with whom she falls in love. (*Twelfth Night*)